Report Writing: Types, Format & Structure

WHAT IS A REPORT?

A report is an account of or a statement about something that happened in the past.

- **A piece of factual writing, based on evidence, containing organized information and/or analysis of a particular topic.**
- Transmits certain **facts, ideas, suggestions** or describes **an event or a condition**.
- **Important**
  - as a basic **management tool** used in **decision-making and problem solving**,
  - as a measure of the **growth, progress, or success** of an organization,
  - valuable **repository of information**.

OBJECTIVES OF REPORTS

- Present a record of accomplished work (**project report**)
- Record an experiment (**primary research report/laboratory report**)
- Document schedules, timetables, and milestones (a **status report** on a long-term plan)
- Document current status (**an inspection report**)
- Present information to a large number of people (**annual report**)
- Recommend actions that can be considered in solving certain problems (**recommendatory report**)

TYPES OF TECHNICAL REPORTS

On the basis of purpose, frequency, mode of reporting, length, approach, and target audience, reports can be classified as follows:

- **Informative, analytical (purpose)**
- **Periodic, special (frequency)**
- **Oral, written (mode of presentation)**
- **Formal, informal (approach)**

ON THE BASIS OF PURPOSE

INFORMATIVE REPORT

Provides information

- Includes .
  - **Introduction**
  - **Information or facts**
  - **Conclusion**
  - **Recommendations not included in this type of report.**
- **Purpose-** to present the information in an objective, factual, and organized manner.

ANALYTICAL REPORT

Also known as **interpretative or investigative** report. Provides **interpretation and analysis.**

- It-
  - **Analyses of the facts**
  - **Draws conclusions**
  - **Makes recommendations.**
- **Purpose** – to present facts and suggest solutions

ON THE BASIS OF FREQUENCY

Periodic Report

- Prepared and presented at regular, prescribed intervals
- Submitted **annually, semi-annually, quarterly, monthly, fortnightly, weekly, or even daily.**

e.g. **Annual assessment reports of employees** to the higher authorities.

Special Report

Related to a **single occasion or situation**

- Special reports deal with **non-recurrent problems**.
- A report on the **feasibility of opening a new branch**,

ON THE BASIS OF MODE OF PRESENTATION

Oral reports	Written reports
• Immediate feedback is possible	• Immediate feedback is not possible
• Do not add to the permanent records of the organization as the information/facts can be denied	• Contribute to the permanent records of the organization
• Audience needs to comprehend quickly as and when these are presented	• Audience can ponder over these reports and understand at its own pace
• May be encumbered with irrelevant facts and overlook important ones	• Are more accurate and precise as the writer will be careful in putting down the facts in writing
• Cannot be referred to again and again	• Can be edited, reviewed, stored, and retrieved
• Have less professional value	• Have more professional value

ON THE BASIS OF APPROACH

FORMAL REPORT

Result of proper survey and investigation.

- **Presented in a prescribed format.**
- **Formal language**
- **The length: a few pages to large volume.**

  (annual reports, auditor's reports, policy reports, thesis, dissertation)

INFORMAL REPORT

Transmitted from person to person.

- **A few lines to several pages.**
- **Targeted at a few people.**
- **Can be added in a letter or memo**

FORMAT OF WRITING REPORTS

A report may have any one of the following formats:

- **Memo**
- **Letter**
- **Pre-printed form**
- **Manuscript**

MEMO FORMAT

Sent to somebody within the organization will be in a memo format.

- The **analysis, conclusions, and recommendations** are included in the main text part of the memorandum.
- Written on the **letterhead**
- **Inside address or salutations are not required.**
- The main body of the memo report includes **headings** appropriate to the discussed matter.
- Sometimes the memo report is signed or initialled at the end.
- Most organizations have a **printed format** for memos

SAMPLE MEMO REPORT

MODERN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY
JAIPUR (RAJASTHAN)

INTEROFFICE MEMORANDUM

To: Dean, Students Welfare Division
From: Chief Warden
Date: 15 October 2014
Subject: Negative effects of Internet facilities

Please refer to your letter No. SWD/IM/2003 in which you have asked me to study the negative effects of Internet facilities provided by the Institute. I would like to present my findings and recommendations.

Findings

The data for the report was collected by interviews with wardens, Mess Managers and the Chief of Information Processing Centre. Also, the medical records of the students were collected from the office of the Chief Medical Officer.

Physical Problems

A preliminary look into the medical records shows that about 75% of the students owning a computer and regular users of the IPC have complained about some physical problem or the other during the past one year. Dr R.K. Sen, Chief Medical Officer, told me that these were the symptoms of Carpal Tunnel Syndrome (CTS), a deadly disease that affects many computer users all over the globe. He also explained that these were due to excessive time spent in front of the computer, improper sitting posture, and the lack of physical exercise amongst the students. Also lack of proper sleep is a cause of this fast growing disease.

Academic Performance

Another disturbing trend has been the decline in academic standards of the student. Most of the wardens and teachers have complained about the declining academic output of the students since the facility was provided to the students. From the talks with Dr T. Bansal, Chief, IPC, I have concluded that most of the students make improper use of the Internet facility. The most common use is for chatting and watching movies over the Web. Though listening to music is also attributed as a problem, one may say that music is good for the students as it has a soothing effect. This abuse of the facility hampers the mental development of the student. Many have got so hooked to it that they live in a virtual world and the only friends they have are chat friends. This is an alarming fact and the trend must be stopped from growing.

Food Habits

The food habits of the students have also been a cause of concern lately. Most Mess Managers agree that the attendance for meals has gone down considerably since the last year, after the introduction of the computer centre. Also, the growing use of junk food by the students is a cause of concern, according to Dr Sen.

Recommendations

Given below are a few suggestions which may help in tackling the problem in question:

- The amount of time spent by a student in the computer lab should be fixed to no more than 4 hours. This can be easily implemented according to the IPC Chief.
- Undesirable sites should be blocked.
- Awareness should be raised among students about CTS and also how to prevent it.
- Considering Dr Sen's advice, chairs in the computer centre should be changed to specially designed ones for more comfort.
- Student participation in sports and cultural activities must be encouraged to shift their attention from computers.
- The computer lab must be shut down between 12 PM and 9 AM to give students proper rest.

I hope that this report will give you an insight into the nature of the problem and also its possible solutions. I would be glad to provide any clarification or additional information required in this regard.

Amit Goyal
Chief Warden

LETTER FORMAT

Short reports sent to outsiders

- Besides all the routine parts of a letter, these reports may include **headings, illustrations, and footnotes**.
- One of the most **personalized forms of reports**

  (depends upon the relationship between the writer and the audience)

SAMPLE LETTER REPORT

SINLEY DISTRIBUTING COMPANY
3204 Jawaharlal Marg, New Delhi

Mr S.S. Moondra
September 27, 2014
Akshay Supermarket
Vidya Vihar
Pilani, Rajasthan

Dear Mr Moondra:

Subject: Advantages of Fully Stocked Shelves

As inquiries are increasing from several supermarket executives concerning grocery and drug shelf stocking, I have undertaken an investigation to determine the effect of fully stocked shelves on sales. This survey has been made considering representative grocery and drug products, with attention given to percentage increases through mass stocking.

Effect of Diversification

Seven supermarkets were surveyed, with several brands of products checked for a two-week period under normal shelf-stocking conditions, and then for two more weeks under fully stocked shelf conditions. Enclosed is the complete result of the survey: below is a simple breakdown:

Table 1: Sales in Relation to Number of Items Stocked

	On Total Grocery Product Sales	On Total Drug Sales	On All Products
Number of items checked	128	69	197
2 weeks' unit sales under normal conditions	8,404	607	9,011
2 weeks' unit sales when shelves were kept fully stocked	10,287	902	11,189
Change in percentage	+22.4%	+48.5%	+24.2%

If you notice the change in the percentage of sales resulting from fully stocking the shelves, it is obvious that this procedure is of tremendous value:

Grocery product sales ..... 22.4 per cent increase
Drug product sales ..... 48.5 per cent increase
All products sales ..... 24.2 per cent increase

Margin and Turnover

We all know that it is the desire of every supermarket to offer goods at the lowest possible prices. This can be accomplished only by reducing markup and increasing stock turnover. Now, if you can increase sales on all products by 24.2 per cent merely by fully stocking your shelves, it is apparent that you will be able to reduce markups and offer merchandise at lower prices. By your giving maximum exposure to different commodities, the consumer has the opportunity to see more and as a result is motivated to purchase something that would never have entered his mind if certain brands had not caught his eye.

The rise in the general standard of living has caused a proportional increase in the demand for service. By our very nature, we cannot offer personalized service; therefore, we must do the next best thing—give intensive exposure to a large variety of brands. That is, substitute displays and printed selling appeals of various manufacturers for personal selling. The consumer is still our livelihood, and the more he sees, the more he will buy.

Recommendations

I suggest that you keep your shelves fully stocked at all times to increase sales of merchandise. It has always been our policy to sell through our retailers, which has been brought to light by the survey.

Yours sincerely
M.K. Hingle
President

PRE-PRINTED FORM

Reports containing routine matter and which are periodical in nature may be written in a form prescribed by the organization.

- All one needs to do is **to fill in the blanks** in a pre-printed form.
- For instance, a report informing **the condition of equipment** in a laboratory may be presented in a printed form wherein the reporter needs to fill in certain details against the details asked for.

SAMPLE INSPECTION REPORT

EXCEL Technovation Pvt. Ltd
Ph. No. 377919 Fax: 0141-37978
CUSTOMER CALL FEEDBACK REPORT

Call Registration Number: _____ Date : _____
Customer: _____
Location: _____

Sys. Model:	**Sl.No.:**	**Peripheral/Add-on Model:**	**Sl. No.:**	
Service Type	Warranty/AMC/IRB/ Chargeable/Others	**Product**	Home PC/Desktop/Server/ Sun/IBM/Datacomm/ SW/Peripheral/Others	
Call Type	Ins/CM/PM/Proj/Upj/Upg/Siteinsp/Others		**Call Category**	**HW/SW**

Problem Reported:

Event	**Date**	**Time**	**Event**	**Date**	**Time**
Call Reported			Start of Service		
Call Assigned			End of Service		
Travel Time			Engineer Hands on Time		

Action Taken:

Call Status: ☐ Closed ☐ Pending for Spares ☐ Pending for Customers ☐ Pending for Others

Part Replaced: ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Under observation

	Part Number	**Part Description**	**Quantity**	**Part Serial No.**
Part Replaced				
Part Removed				

For Customer's Use: Please rate this call by ticking an option:

☐ Extremely Dissatisfied ☐ Dissatisfied ☐ Neither Satisfied nor Dissatisfied
☐ Satisfied ☐ Extremely Satisfied

Customer's Feedback: _____

User Name :
Email ID/Tel.No :
Signature :
Date :

Engineer Name :
Signature :
Date :

MANUSCRIPT FORMAT

Commonly used format/used for formal reports.

- **The length**: can range from a few pages to several hundred.
- Can be **used for all types of reports**—informational, analytical, or routine.
- Include **more elements**: abstract, summary, appendix, glossary, and so on.

STRUCTURE/PARTS OF REPORTS (MANUSCRIPT FORMAT)

1. Title page
2. Preface
3. Letter of Transmittal
4. Acknowledgements
5. Table of Contents
6. List of Illustrations
7. Abstract/Executive summary
8. Introduction
9. Methodology
10. Discussion/Finding/Analysis
11. Conclusion
12. Recommendation
13. Appendices
14. References and Bibliography

STRUCTURE OF REPORTS

It has three basic parts:

Front Matter- the preparatory part

Main Body

Back Matter- the supplementary part

FRONT MATTER

FRONT MATTER consists of the following parts:

- **Cover Page-** it includes the title of the report, authority to whom it is submitted, date and author's name
- **Frontispiece-** (optional) – any extra map, picture or drawing related to the topic of the report
- **Title Page-** similar to the cover page but also includes name and designation of the approving authority along with the title of the report, authority to whom it is submitted, date and author's name.
- **Copyright notice** –(optional) a written document written to secure one's original work.

FRONT MATTER

- **Certificate-** (optional) some project reports require a certificate to state that the work is original. It is generally given by the project supervisor.
- **Forwarding letter** –(optional) written by someone other than the author to introduce the author and the work.
- **Acknowledgements-** a thank you note written to give credit to all the people or organizations who have directly or indirectly helped in writing the report.
- **Preface-** an introduction written by the author to state the factors leading to the writing of the report, to highlight the various features of the report, its significance

FRONT MATTER

- **Table of contents-** includes the various topics and headings with their page numbers.
- **List of Illustrations-**(optional) it is a content list for all the illustrations that appear in the report like graphs, charts, maps, drawings with their page numbers.
- **Abstract-** a summary of the report, the essence of the entire report without any illustrations. Length is only 2-5 % of the report

MAIN BODY

The main text gives the details of the study.

- **Introduction-** includes the background of the report, purpose and scope of the report, basic principles and theories involved, methods of gathering data, brief outline of methodology, organization of various sections.
- **Discussion/ description/ methodology-** in this section information and data is presented, analysed and interpreted, it also includes description of method used with tables, charts etc.
- **Conclusion-** it includes logical inferences drawn or judgement formed on the basis of analysis done of data presented in discussion or description, or the findings of investigation.
- **Recommendation-** suggestion for future course of action, steps to solve the problem. It is preferably written in points or tabular form.

BACK MATTER

The supporting part

- **Appendices**-(optional) some extra information that is of relevance to the report but could not be fitted in the text.
- **References**- an alphabetical list of sources- books, magazines, newspapers, websites, interviews that are **quoted** for particular piece of information in the report.
- **Bibliography**- an alphabetical list of sources- books, magazines, newspapers, websites, interviews that have been **consulted** in writing the report (may or may not be quoted from).
- **Glossary-**(optional) list of technical words used in the report and their explanations
- **Index** –(optional) a quick guide for the reader to locate the topic and the sub-topic.

A Report
on
Fatal Road Accidents during 2004–2014

By
Sriram Raichuri
Senior Traffic Inspector
Department of Traffic and Signal Control, New Delhi

28 November 2014

A Report

R. No. B239/2014

on

Fatal Road Accidents during 2004–2014: A Case Study of New Delhi

Prepared

for

Ujjawal Pratap Singh
Director
Traffic Police, New Delhi

By

Sriram Raichuri
Senior Traffic Inspector

Approved by
Abhishek Sayal
Deputy Director
Traffic and Signal Control

Department of Traffic and Signal Control, New Delhi
28 November 2014

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LIST OF ILLUSTRATIONS

Tables

Table 1 ——— 1
Table 2 ——— 8
Table 3 ——— 12
Table 4 ——— 14

Figures

Figure 1 ——— 3
Figure 2 ——— 9
Figure 3 ——— 22

Table of Contents

Acknowledgements *ii*
Abstract *iii*

1. Introduction 1
2. An Overview of Employment Trend during Last Five Years 3
   - 2.1 Electronics 4
   - 2.2 Software 6
   - 2.3 Pharmaceutical 9
   - 2.4 Construction 12
   - 2.5 Hospitality industry 15
   - 2.6 Medical 18
3. Overall Pattern 20
4. Conclusions 22
5. Recommendations 24

Appendix *26*
References *28*
Index *30*

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Preface 1
Acknowledgement 2
List of illustrations 3
Abstract 4

1. Introduction 6
2. Methodology 9
3. Discussion 10
4. Conclusion 15
5. Recommendations 19

Appendices 20
References 28

Sample Abstract

This report is based on the profile study of ten top most business leaders. It analyses the various factors such as risk-taking abilities, inventiveness, adaptability, resilience, and business acumen among these leaders. It also suggests an existence of strong correlation between effective risk-taking with strategy-based innovation. The report serves as an effective introduction to cross-factor analysis of effective leadership. It has implication for HR in a situation when they are finding top leaders to lead a firm towards innovation, grow its revenues, or turn around the company in crisis.

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I owe a lot to my parents for being my constant motivation to work hard. Above all, I thank Virender and Sushila, my friends, who have been instrumental in the successful compilation and presentation of this report.

I also thank Mr Rakesh Saini, the binder for giving it an elegant shape.

STYLE OF REPORTS

Provide complete and accurate information

This year the firm has incurred high profits.

~~This year the firm has incurred 4.8% more profit as compared to the last year.~~

Use plain and familiar words

The committee will *decipher* (find out) the factors responsible for lack of *synergy* (cooperation) between the two departments.

Avoid wordiness and redundancy

Tsunami had the effect of destructive, disparaging and caustic impact on the manufacturing plant.

Tsunami destroyed the manufacturing plant.

Judiciously use active and passive voice

You have not yet informed me.

I have not been yet intimated.

Carefully use acronyms and abbreviations

- **Acronyms- shortened phrase, pronounceable- NATO, SAARC, UNISCO**
- **Abbreviations- Shortened word- Mrs,Mr, Pvt.**

Avoid cliches

- **Last but not least- finally**

Maintain unity in paragraphs

Avoid punctuation and grammatical errors